

Smart India Hackathon 2026 — what I need to ask

Harsh Bajpai · for faculty / the Programme Office · 17 September 2026

IIM Mumbai is registered for SIH 2026. The Institute appears at row 89 of the official list on sih.gov.in/know-your-spoc, AISHE code **U-1283**, with **Dr. Puja Sarkar** as Single Point of Contact. I have written to her separately. So the route exists — my questions are about what comes next.

The portal closes on 30 September 2026. That is confirmed on sih.gov.in itself, on every problem-statement page. An earlier guidelines PDF saying 15th September has been superseded.

As a university-level AISHE code the Institute may nominate up to **100 teams**; I am asking about one, of six students, with a built and tested entry for ISRO's problem statement **SIH26171**.

My questions

1. Our team of six is ready and our idea is built. **What does the Institute need from us to nominate it** before the portal closes on 30 September? If there is an internal cut-off earlier than that date, I would like to work to it rather than to the national one.
2. The guidelines make an **internal hackathon mandatory** — only teams selected in one may be nominated. Is the Institute running one? If not, would a **minimal round** serve: a panel of two or three faculty, an hour, our demonstration and any other team that wants to present. I understand very few teams are likely to apply this year.
3. That round has to be **written up by the SPOC** — up to fifteen pages with photographs, the jury panel and the judging process. **I am offering to prepare that document** so it costs the SPOC an approval rather than an evening. Is that acceptable?
4. Who would **sign and seal the nomination letter** on Institute letterhead — the Director, or a Dean? It has to name all six team members and carry the Institute seal.
5. There are two official forms — a **College Consent Letter** and a **College Authorization Letter**. I have both blank templates. Who should fill them, and to whom do I return them? **They must not be reformatted** — the template says a changed format is grounds for disqualification, so I have not touched them.
6. Is there **anything the Institute needs from us in writing** — the team list, roll numbers, the problem statement, a one-page summary of the project? I can have any of it the same day.
7. Is there **anyone else I should be speaking to** about this instead of you?

The project is ready — **Aavaran**, a working browser extension built for ISRO's problem statement SIH26171, running on Chrome and Firefox with tested, reproducible results, and installable on a laptop in about a minute if anyone would like to see it. I am not asking the Institute to build anything, only to nominate us.